

Cedar Mountain Hideout at Cook's Spring

During the anti-polygamy raids in the 1880's, Henry Lunt, Francis Webster, and C. J. Arthur spent a winter at Corry's Ranch on Cedar Mountain, also known as Cook's Spring. From the Henry Lunt biography, the last half of Chapter 24:



A monument commemorates the stay of Henry Lunt, Francis Webster, and C.J. Arthur at a cabin at Cook's Springs on Square Mountain near Cedar City during the winter of 1887. A cement foundation and a few logs on the site are remnants of the cabin.

After Henry came home from his mission to England, he spent a long cold winter in hiding, sometimes with Francis Webster and C. J. Arthur, at "Cook's Spring" on the mountain south of Cedar City.

Cook's Spring is on Cedar Mountain [south of "Henry Mountain"] or what is now called "Square Mountain," south and east of Cedar City. The three men came to the rim once each week to receive mail and supplies from their sons who battled through deep snow drifts to reach them.

The men often sat looking down upon the silent city and could see the smoke curling from the

chimneys of their own homes. Sometimes smoke signals were sent from those chimneys--one puff meant "the boys have gone and are on the way to bring supplies," two puffs meant "all is well," and three puffs meant "we send our love." They probably had other signals.

The following is an entry taken from C. J. Arthur's journal:

February 14, 1887: Three weeks on the mountain southeast of Cedar City In company with Henry Lunt and Francis Webster, we started on horseback with packs behind our saddles at 4 o'clock in the morning for Corry's Ranch, Cook's Spring, immediately southeast of the Square Mountain – Cedar City, about six miles distance in a southeast direction. We wended our way steadily and slowly (through a south 'hurricane' throwing up the sand and gravel right in our faces, in a most fearful manner) for about three miles up the mountain, and camped about 6 a.m. in the Cedars to await our pack train and the boys, Henry Lunt Jr. and Francis Webster Jr., each of whom rode a horse and led another, packed. We made a fire, for it was extremely cold, and waited till 8 a.m. when they came along. The boys now took the lead and we followed up, passing along up the mountains through snowdrifts till we

reached the top where we discovered the snow on the level to be 2½ feet deep. Henry Lunt, Jr. made the attempt to ascend the hill, the nearest road to Corry's Ranch about ½ mile distance. His horse floundered so that he gave it up and returned to us; then we struck up the old road leading to the ranches, generally.

We managed to wallow through and arrived at the ranch, about ½ past 10 the same morning, where we found an immense lot of snow in the upper and lower chambers and about two foot around the house and a bank or drift close by, 20 feet deep. We soon made a fire, warmed up, and threw a portion of the snow out of the lower chamber, which soon tired us out, not being used to work. The boys had dinner, fed the horses the oats and chaff we brought along and, after warming up good, left us about ½ past 3 p.m. We got some food together on the table we found in the cabin and ate dinner, then fitted up a stationary bedstead and made a bed thereon where myself and Brother Lunt slept. Brother Webster made his bed on the floor before the fire. We retired early and slept sound.

February 15: Clearing up a little. Got our breakfast and then started to clean out the snow and fill up the crevices in the logs with paper, rags and sacks. The lower ones, we banked up the snow outside to keep out the cold blast that blew so bleak and cold on the mountain, about 7000 feet above sea level, after which we took a stroll through the snow towards the top of the hill [by] the nearest route. Brother Lunt and I stayed about 2/3 of the way over, while Brother Webster continued on to the top. We were absent from the cabin about 3 hours. We concluded a shorter cut could be found than the one we came. We had a storm tonight and the wind blew cold.

February 16: Fine day. After breakfast Brother Webster and I took a trip in an oblique line, striking for the 3 pines on the top of the bank near the top of the hill which was, ever after, our landmark. I traveled on snowshoes. We made a track and cut out a road down the bank so the boys could travel up. Brother Lunt stayed and chopped wood. I may state here that I was promoted 'cook,' Brother Webster, 'assistant,' and Brother Lunt, 'wood chopper.' All of us, more or less, assisted. We only ate two meals a day, going to bed about midnight and getting up about 9:30 in the morning.

February 17: Willy Lunt and Thomas Webster came up this morning with supplies – they had to pack them about 1½ miles on their backs – also, the mail. We met them near the pines. Brother Lunt and I took their loads and they, with Brother Webster, went back for the balance of the load they brought up. They stayed about 2 hours and left us. It was snowing and blowing terrifically.

February 24: 'Twas today we cleared out the upper chamber, also the lower one and fixed up the chinks, making the room more comfortable and cozy. I stewed a rabbit for supper and made a crust to cover, which we called a pot pie, and managed to dispose of it all, enjoying our feast very much. The wind raised and we had a heavy, driving storm. Very cold.

February 26: Lovely calm night, beautiful morning, calm and mild. After breakfast, melted snow, had a good bath and changed underclothes. The bath has freshened me up – skin peeling off my face. Brother Lunt complaining of being sick. F. Webster and I nailed the 'factory [cloth]' on the poles and put it overhead for a ceiling.

March 4: Very windy and cold last night, snow drifted which fell and came freely through every little crack to windward. A little mouse ran over our bed in the night. Sun shining and snow melting this morning. Toast, cake, fruit and remnants of pot pie for breakfast. I feel quite sick at my stomach. Concluded it was the fruit which we kept covered up in the new camp kettle, it was frothy, I think probably poisoned by the galvanized metal. All felt the effects of it more or less. I felt worse as I warmed my fruit. It operated on my stomach, like swallowing the juice of a quid of tobacco, for almost three hours, then it went away.

March 5. Webster and I started on snow shoes to meet the boys with mail and supplies. Left at 20 to 12 and made the trip in 30 minutes. Our meal last night has regulated all our bowels. We had to wait at 3 pines about 1¾ hours. Presently Willy Lunt made his appearance on horseback. We released him of most of his burden and returned.

March 7: W. Lunt came at about 3 o'clock p.m. and brought me a letter from the Auditor of the Post Office Department – Washington, giving us another chance to make an offer of compromise of settlement in Chatterly's fraud Post Office business. The brethren decided I should go home and attend to it. I started with Willy Lunt at 6 and arrived at the County Bridge, Cedar City at 8, making the trip in little more than 2 hours. Found all the folks well, a letter from President John Taylor awaited me instructing me to turn all Church property that was in my control over to the Church Association, Parowan Stake of Zion. I footed the journey down about half way wearing my new boots. I blistered my feet very much.

On the trip, which we did to keep clear of the Marshals who desired us for practicing the Laws of Heaven, I can say that the first 10 days were the most severe of any winter I ever experienced. The latter part was warmer, altogether we got along pretty well and feel to thank the Lord for his preserving care over us during our absence from home, family and friends.¹

Each time the boys brought food, they brought mail and papers for the three men to read. Henry usually stayed at the cabin and chopped wood. Because of his eyes, it was difficult for him to see well enough to travel to the mountain crest where they picked up the supplies. Although C. J. Arthur came down, Webster and Lunt stayed on the mountain most of the winter. Arthur probably went back up the mountain later.

¹ C. J. Arthur, "Diary of C. J. Arthur," Provo, UT, B.Y.U. Library, Part 5, pp. 28-37.